

# *The Ransom of Red Chief*

O. Henry · 1907

First published: Saturday Evening Post, Jul 1907

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

*Cover: Claude Monet, Springtime (1872). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).*

# Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

**Edition:** Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_ransom_of_Red_Chief_and_other_O._Henry_stories_for_boys/The_Ransom_Of_Red_Chief (revision 13357856), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

**Grades:** Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

## Essential questions

- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about comic reversal?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about greed?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about childhood?

## Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

## Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

**Primary codes:** RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
**Assessments:** Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
**Differentiation:** Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
**Materials:** Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

## The 90-minute lesson

| # | Segment | Mode | Minutes | Clock |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bell-ringer | You do | 8 | 0–8 |
| 2 | Vocabulary with etymology notes | I do | 10 | 8–18 |
| 3 | Background and context | I do | 10 | 18–28 |
| 4 | I do: modeled close reading | I do | 12 | 28–40 |
| 5 | We do: guided annotation | We do | 15 | 40–55 |
| 6 | You do: independent annotation | You do | 15 | 55–70 |
| 7 | Discussion | We do | 10 | 70–80 |
| 8 | Exit ticket / chapter quiz | You do | 7 | 80–87 |
| 9 | Closure | I do | 3 | 87–90 |
| | **Total** | | **90** | |

# Syllabus

| Week | Chapters | Lessons | Focus and activities | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Ransom of Red Chief | 1 × 90 min (90 min) | *comic reversal*<br>• Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure<br>• Story quizzes in the app<br>• Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week) | Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt |

# Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

# Lesson 1: The Ransom of Red Chief

**Focus:** a crime that backfires

**Content note (kidnapping played for comedy, dated stereotypes in a child playing "indian"):** Sensitive content: Kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian". Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
**Student preview:** Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian".
**Suggested language:** "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.

**Background:** Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang.

**Significance:** A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.

*Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)*

**0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
*Settle in and write for five minutes: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian".*

**8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
*Today's words are dictating, playmate, egotism, patched, humiliating. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid." In this sentence it means: issue commands or orders for. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.*

**18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)**
Present the historical and literary background.
*Here is what the first readers of The Ransom of Red Chief would have known. Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. Why does this story matter? A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary. Write down one question you want answered.*

**28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)**
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
*Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a crime that backfires? I circle "humiliating", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.*

**40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)**
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
*Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.*

> *Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill. They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars. It's an awful thing to hear a strong, desperate, fat man scream incontinently in a cave at daybreak.*

**55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)**
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
*Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Characterization, Diction / vocabulary: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.*

**70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)**
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
*Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to comic reversal? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.*

**80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
*Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a crime that backfires, backed by one short quotation.*

**87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
*Today we saw how irony shapes a crime that backfires. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

### *Vocabulary with etymology notes*

| Word | Definition (in this sentence) | In context | Word history |
|---|---|---|---|
| **dictating** (verb) | issue commands or orders for | *Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **playmate** (noun) | a companion at play | *He's your playmate for the day.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **egotism** (noun) | too much concern with oneself | *I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **patched** (adjective) | hastily put together | *Itook the rock away from the boy and kind of patched up the argument. "I'll fix you," says the kid to Bill. "No man ever yet struck the Red Chief but what he got paid for it.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **humiliating** (verb) | cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of | *They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **impudent** (adjective) | marked by casual disrespect | *"Great pirates of Penzance!" says I; "of all the impudent——"* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **vicinity** (noun) | a surrounding or nearby region | *Iwent up on the peak of the little mountain and ran my eye over the contiguous vicinity.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **elevation** (noun) | a lifting up; high spirits | *On the rear elevation of this mountain was a cave.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| | | *"No," says Bill, "nothing chronic except malaria and accidents.* | |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **accidents** (noun) | an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury | | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **spending** (verb) | pass time in a specific way | *His folks may think he's spending the night with Aunt Jane or one of the neighbours.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

### *Discussion questions*

1. Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with comic reversal?

### *Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)*

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

**Literal / recall**

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: To collect a ransom
2. What does the boy call himself? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Red Chief
3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He enjoys it as an adventure
4. What does the father propose? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
5. Who suffers most from the boy's games? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Bill
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Ransom of Red Chief” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Ransom of Red Chief”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Ransom of Red Chief” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.” What does “dictating” mean here, and what is literally

happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dictating: issue commands or orders for.

10. Reread: “He's your playmate for the day.” What does “playmate” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: playmate: a companion at play.

**Inferential / analytical**

1. What does “The Ransom of Red Chief” suggest about a crime that backfires? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a crime that backfires? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. In the passage that begins “Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Ransom of Red Chief”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Ransom of Red Chief” set up that the rest of The Ransom of Red Chief will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with comic reversal? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
10. Background: Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

**Evaluative / synthesis / creative**

1. A critic might argue: "A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Ransom of Red Chief" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Ransom of Red Chief": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to greed: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Ransom of Red Chief" treats a crime that backfires with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Ransom of Red Chief see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve comic reversal? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

## *Annotation focus*

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

## *Chapter quiz*

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?

   A. To teach him a lesson

   B. Because he is lost

C. To collect a ransom

D. To get revenge on his father

2. What does the boy call himself?

A. Red Chief

B. Chief Dorset

C. Old Hank

D. Black Scout

3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?

A. He is terrified

B. He enjoys it as an adventure

C. He is bored

D. He tries to escape

4. What does the father propose?

A. He calls the sheriff

B. He refuses to answer

C. He pays double

D. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back

5. Who suffers most from the boy's games?

A. Sam

B. Bill

C. The father

D. The sheriff

6. In the line “Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”, what does “dictating” most nearly mean?

A. too much concern with oneself

B. hastily put together

C. issue commands or orders for

D. a companion at play

7. In the line “He's your playmate for the day.”, what does “playmate” most nearly mean?

A. hastily put together

B. too much concern with oneself

C. issue commands or orders for

D. a companion at play

**Answer key:** 1. C (To collect a ransom); 2. A (Red Chief); 3. B (He enjoys it as an adventure); 4. D (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back); 5. B (Bill); 6. C (issue commands or orders for); 7. D (a companion at play)

### *Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)*

**Middle School** (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Ransom of Red Chief,” how does Henry show a crime that backfires? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

**HS Freshman** (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Ransom of Red Chief, how does Henry develop the idea of a crime that backfires? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

**HS Sophomore** (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**HS Senior** (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Ransom of Red Chief suggests about a crime that backfires. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**AP** (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Ransom of Red Chief to complicate the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

**College Freshman** (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Ransom of Red Chief within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a crime that backfires responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

**College Sophomore** (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Ransom of Red Chief alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a crime that backfires follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

**College Junior** (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Ransom of Red Chief and its treatment of a crime that backfires. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

**College Senior** (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as evidence for a larger claim about a crime that backfires in The Ransom of Red Chief. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

**Graduate / PhD** (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a crime that backfires. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Ransom of Red Chief.

### *SAT-style questions*

1. *I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “egotism” most nearly mean?

   A. too much concern with oneself

   B. pass time in a specific way

   C. a lifting up; high spirits

   D. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury

2. *Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill. They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars. It's an awful thing to hear a strong, desperate, fat man scream incontinently in a cave at daybreak.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Ransom of Red Chief”?

   A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   B. A crime that backfires

   C. Wishes that defy fate

   D. A story told to protect a livelihood

**SAT key:** 1. A (too much concern with oneself); 2. B (A crime that backfires)

# Whole-book test

**The Ransom of Red Chief: whole-book test** · 90 minutes

## Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?
   A. To teach him a lesson
   B. Because he is lost
   C. To collect a ransom
   D. To get revenge on his father
2. What does the boy call himself?
   A. Red Chief
   B. Chief Dorset
   C. Old Hank
   D. Black Scout
3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?
   A. He is terrified
   B. He enjoys it as an adventure
   C. He is bored
   D. He tries to escape
4. What does the father propose?
   A. He calls the sheriff
   B. He refuses to answer
   C. He pays double
   D. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
5. Who suffers most from the boy's games?
   A. Sam
   B. Bill
   C. The father
   D. The sheriff
6. In the line “Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”, what does “dictating” most nearly mean?
   A. too much concern with oneself
   B. hastily put together
   C. issue commands or orders for
   D. a companion at play

7. In the line “He's your playmate for the day.”, what does “playmate” most nearly mean?
   A. hastily put together
   B. too much concern with oneself
   C. issue commands or orders for
   D. a companion at play
8. As used in the story (“Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”), what does “dictating” mean?
   A. issue commands or orders for
   B. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
   C. a lifting up; high spirits
   D. a companion at play
9. As used in the story (“He's your playmate for the day.”), what does “playmate” mean?
   A. marked by casual disrespect
   B. a companion at play
   C. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury
   D. too much concern with oneself
10. As used in the story (“I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance ”), what does “egotism” mean?
    A. a surrounding or nearby region
    B. pass time in a specific way
    C. too much concern with oneself
    D. hastily put together
11. As used in the story (“Itook the rock away from the boy and kind of patched up the argument. "I'll fix you," says the kid to Bill. "No man ever yet struck the Red ”), what does “patched” mean?
    A. a lifting up; high spirits
    B. issue commands or orders for
    C. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
    D. hastily put together
12. As used in the story (“They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecen”), what does “humiliating” mean?
    A. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
    B. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury
    C. a companion at play
    D. marked by casual disrespect

## Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how comic reversal develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how greed develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how childhood develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

## Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (comic reversal, greed, childhood) and argue how the ending reframes it.

## Answer key

**Answer key:** 1. C (To collect a ransom); 2. A (Red Chief); 3. B (He enjoys it as an adventure); 4. D (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back); 5. B (Bill); 6. C (issue commands or orders for); 7. D (a companion at play); 8. A (issue commands or orders for); 9. B (a companion at play); 10. C (too much concern with oneself); 11. D (hastily put together); 12. A (cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of)

# Essay assignments

## Essay: Comic reversal

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about comic reversal. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops comic reversal across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of comic reversal. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of comic reversal, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of comic reversal in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Greed

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops greed across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Childhood

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about childhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops childhood across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of childhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of childhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of childhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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